

Estate Manager — Configuration Guide

Setup and configuration for **Estate Manager**: starting the app, user accounts and roles, system settings, and the SMS/email notification integrations.

Related documents

- [USER MANUAL.md](#) — day-to-day use of the system.
- [DEPLOYMENT.md](#) — hosting the system online for demos.
- [TROUBLESHOOTING.md](#) — fixing common problems.

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1. Starting the app

Requirements: **Node.js 16+** and **npm**.

From the project folder:

```
npm run dev
```

This starts:

- the **web app** at <http://localhost:5173> — open in your browser
- the **API server** on port **4000** — used by the app

Two-terminal alternative:

```
# terminal 1 — API
cd server && npm run dev
# terminal 2 — web app
cd client && npm run dev
```

⚠ The API server loads its code **once at start**. If the code changes (e.g. after an update), restart with `Ctrl+C` and run `npm run dev` again, or new features/report endpoints will appear missing (see [TROUBLESHOOTING.md](#)).

The database file lives at `server/data/estate.db` and is created automatically with demo data (3 properties, 48 units, sample tenants/leases/payments) the first time it runs.

2. Default login & initial password

The first run creates an **admin** account:

Username	Password	Role
admin	admin123	Admin

⚠ **Change the default password immediately after first login:** sidebar → **Change password**. Enter the current password and a new one (6+ characters).

Passwords are stored hashed. If the password is lost, reset the demo data (see [Backup & reset](#)) — this restores `admin / admin123`.

3. Users & roles

Only a **User** account with the **admin** role can open the **Users** tab.

Roles

Role	Access
Admin	Everything, including the Users tab
Manager	All business features (properties, units, tenants, onboarding, payments, reports, renewals, utilities, notifications, activity, settings). Cannot manage users.

Creating a user

1. Open **Users** (admin only) → **+ Add user**.
2. Enter **username**, **full name**, **password** (6+ chars) and a **role**.
3. Click **Add user**.

Editing / passwords

- **Edit** — change the full name or role, or set a new password (leave blank to keep the current one).

Disabling & deleting

- **Disable / Enable** — block a user from signing in without deleting the account.
- **Delete** — remove the user (a reason is required).

Safety rules

- An admin **cannot delete themselves**.
- The **last remaining admin** cannot be removed.

4. The Settings page

The **Settings** page (⚙ in the sidebar) controls three areas:

1. **Lease renewals** — renewal-reminder look-ahead (see below).
2. **Utility rates** — water & electricity cost per unit.
3. **SMS / email integrations** — notification providers and test messages.

After changing values click **Save settings**. Changes apply immediately and are recorded in the [Activity](#) trail.

5. Automated renewal reminders

- **Send expiry reminders N months ahead** (`renewal_reminder_months` , default **2**) sets how early the engine looks for expiring leases.
 - The engine targets **active** leases that expire within the look-ahead **and** haven't been notified yet (`notice_sent` = false).
 - Runs automatically on **server start** and every **6 hours**. It can also be triggered manually from the Notifications page (► **Run automated reminders now**).
 - Each lease also carries its own **renewal frequency** (months) — set at [onboarding](#) or when editing a lease — which is used in the reminder text and on renew.
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6. Utility rates

Set the cost per unit on the **Settings** page (or the **Utility rates** card on the **Utilities** page):

- **Water** — KES per m³
- **Electricity** — KES per kWh

These are defaults; an individual reading can override its rate.

7. SMS integration (Africa's Talking)

On the **Settings** page, under **SMS — Africa's Talking**:

1. Toggle **Send SMS notifications** on.
2. Enter your **Username** and **API key** from your Africa's Talking account.
3. Optionally set a **Sender ID** (e.g. `EstateManager`).
4. Leave **Sandbox mode** on for testing, or switch to **Live** when ready.

Notes:

- Sandbox mode uses Africa's Talking's sandbox endpoint (free, no real SMS sent).
 - The API key is masked after saving (`.....`). Leave the field blank to keep the existing key — it is never returned by the system.
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8. Email integration (SMTP)

On the **Settings** page, under **Email — SMTP**:

1. Toggle **Send email notifications** on.
2. Enter the **SMTP host**, **Port** (587 with STARTTLS, or 465 for direct TLS), **Username**, **Password** and **From address** (e.g. `Estate Manager <no-reply@example.com>`).

Any standard SMTP account works (hosted mail, Gmail app passwords, Zoho, etc.). The password is masked after saving; leave blank to keep it.

9. Test messages & simulated mode

Send a test (Settings → **Send a test message**):

1. Choose the **channel** (SMS or Email).
2. Enter a **recipient** (phone for SMS, email address for Email).
3. Click **Send test**.

The result badge shows **Sent ✓**, **Simulated ✓** or **Failed ✗** with the error. Test messages are recorded on the Notifications page and in the activity trail.

Simulated mode

Until real credentials are configured, every message is marked **simulated**:

- No real SMS/email is sent and nothing is charged.
- Delivery is still recorded so you can preview exactly what would be sent.
- Once credentials are added and the channel is enabled, messages switch to **sent / failed** automatically.

10. Backup & reset

Backup

All data lives in one file: `server/data/estate.db` .

Stop the server (optional, for full consistency) and copy the file:

```
cp server/data/estate.db server/data/estate.db.bak
```

Reset / re-seed demo data

Restores the demo dataset and a fresh `admin / admin123` account:

```
rm -f server/data/estate.db* && npm run seed
```

⚠ This **wipes all recorded data**. Deleting only the `.db` files (without the `-wal / -shm` sidecars) can cause a corrupted database — always remove them together.